



Form without reward: Over 600 runs at a strike rate above 170 in IPL 2025 still weren't enough to earn Shreyas Iyer a recall.

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Group-stage outings against UAE and Oman, either side of a marquee clash with Pakistan, should provide valuable tune-up time. The Super Four will test them more, but as eight-time Asian champion, and winner of 17 of 20 games since its global triumph, India remains the clear favourite.

Sri Lanka, champion in 2022, is battling form after series defeats to New Zealand and Bangladesh.

Pakistan, meanwhile, has reset by moving on from Babar Azam and Mohammad Rizwan, but remains untested. Bangladesh has beaten

both Sri Lanka and Pakistan recently, but its fragile temperament in multi-team events lingers.

Afghanistan is no longer just a plucky outsider — it has the firepower to push both Sri Lanka and Bangladesh for a Super Four berth.

For host UAE and neighbour Oman, the tournament is a chance to measure themselves against the elite before October's Asia/East Asia-Pacific World Cup qualifiers, where three slots are up for grabs. Hong Kong, winless in 11 Asia Cup matches since its 2004 debut, would cherish even a single victory — a first in over two decades.



HOW THEY ARE STACKED UP

Group A

India
Pakistan
UAE
Oman

Group B

Sri Lanka
Bangladesh
Afghanistan
Hong Kong